Book Club Platform — Business Plan

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Executive summary

We are building India's home for reading together: a web platform (mobile apps later) where readers create and run book clubs, discuss books spoiler-safely, find meetups and bookstores near them, and buy books at the best price. The pitch: **Goodreads tracks what you read. We help you read together — with your club, in your city, in your language.**

- **Wedge:** club organizers. Today most Indian clubs run on WhatsApp + Instagram + Google Meet. We give organizers better tools (spoiler-safe threads, polls, schedules, RSVPs, WhatsApp reminders), and each organizer brings a whole group.
- **Launch:** web only, Bangalore first, Google sign-in, free for readers.
- **Revenue:** organizer subscriptions, event ticketing fees, bookstore listings, affiliate commissions, and later corporate clubs. Readers never pay to join a club.
- **Cost to reach Phase 1 launch:** about 3–4 months of founder engineering time and under ₹15,000/month in infrastructure.
- **Phase 1 goal:** 100 active clubs and 3,000 monthly active readers in Bangalore within 6 months of launch, with 20+ organizers paying.

Problem and opportunity

Indian readers are growing fast, but the tools for reading together are scattered and generic.

The market is growing. NielsenIQ BookData reported Indian book revenue up 20.7% in 2025, the fastest of the territories it tracks, driven by fiction (source). IMARC values the market at about USD 5.1 billion in 2025, with online already the largest sales channel (source). Readers still prefer physical books, and book fairs in Delhi and Chennai each draw around 20 lakh visitors (source).

How clubs run today:

- Discussion lives in WhatsApp groups: spoilers everywhere, threads lost, no history when someone joins late.
- Promotion lives on Instagram; RSVPs and payments are chased by hand.
- Virtual meetings run on Google Meet or Zoom links pasted into the chat.
- Book data lives on Goodreads, which covers Indian and regional-language titles poorly.

What's missing: one place that handles the club's whole life — picking the book, scheduling, discussing safely, meeting online or in person — plus the Indian layer: local stores, INR prices, regional languages and city events.

Product and differentiation

We don't compete with StoryGraph on reading stats. We win on reading *together*, offline life, and the Indian layer — and make switching free with one-click import.

Feature	What it gives users	Goodreads / StoryGraph	Phase
Goodreads / StoryGraph CSV import	Bring years of shelves and ratings in 30 seconds	Export only	1
Club tools: polls, schedule, RSVPs, attendance	Run a club without chasing people on WhatsApp	Basic groups / buddy reads	1
Spoiler-safe discussion by progress	See threads only up to the chapter you've reached	No	1
"I'm reading this" with aggregate counts	See how many readers and clubs near you are on the same book	Individual shelves only	1
Club-scoped DMs	Message people you share a club with	Open or none	1
WhatsApp / email reminders	Members stay where they already are	No	1
Events and meetups near you	Find clubs, silent reads, author talks, lit fests in your city	No	1 (list) / 2 (map)
Price comparison + local stock	Cheapest price across Amazon, Flipkart, partner stores	Amazon link only	1 (affiliate) / 2 (stores)
Indian + regional-language catalog	Native-script search, translations linked	Weak coverage	2
Book swaps and lending in clubs	Pass books on at the next meetup	No	2

Feature	What it gives users	Goodreads / StoryGraph	Phase
Partner bookstore perks	Discounts on the club's current pick	No	2
Personalised recommendations	"Readers in your city and clubs are loving…"	Yes, global	2
Community blogs	Anyone can write; best posts surface	Reviews only	2
Neighbourhood reader map, temporary check-ins	Opt-in, aggregate, coarse location only	No	3
In-app video meetings	Host virtual meetings without leaving the club	No	3

Target users

Organizers come first because each one brings 10–50 readers; readers and bookstores follow.

Persona	Who	What they need	How they pay
Club organizer	Runs a 10–50 member club in a metro; 25–40, working professional	Less admin, no spoilers in chat, RSVPs, a place new members can find them	Organizer plan; ticketing fee on paid events
Social reader	20–35, wants to read more and meet people who read	Clubs and meetups nearby, what others are reading	Free (ads); buys books via affiliate links
Regional-language reader	Reads in Kannada, Hindi, Tamil, Bengali, etc.	Books and clubs in their language	Free; affiliate
Independent bookstore	Bangalore indie or secondhand store	Footfall, discovery, hosting events	Listing / promotion fee
HR / culture team (later)	Tech companies running office clubs	Private clubs, engagement reports	Corporate plan

Competition

Our real competitor is the free WhatsApp + Instagram + Meet stack, not another app.

Competitor	Strength	Gap we exploit
WhatsApp + Instagram + Meet	Free, everyone already uses it	Spoilers, lost threads, no RSVPs, no discovery, no book data
Goodreads	Huge catalog and user base, Amazon-owned	Stagnant product, weak Indian catalog, groups feel abandoned
StoryGraph	Great stats, mood-based recommendations, buddy reads	Individual-first, no offline or local layer, no India focus
Bookclubs.com	Mature club management; Premium $60, Pro $180, Pro Plus $228 per club per year	USD pricing, US-centric books and stores, no Indian events or stores
Meetup	Event discovery	Not book-aware; organizer fees are high

Bookclubs.com validates the model: freemium, organizers pay per club, readers join free. It also charges a 3% fee on paid club memberships on top of Stripe's fees (source) — the same structure we use for ticketing.

Business model and pricing

Readers are always free; organizers, event hosts and bookstores pay. Prices below are starting points to test with the first 20 organizers.

Organizer plans (per club):

Plan	Price	Includes
Free	₹0	1 club, unlimited members, threads, basic polls, events list, ads shown
Club Plus	₹149/month or ₹1,499/year	Up to 3 clubs, spoiler-safe threads, ranked voting, recurring schedules, WhatsApp reminders, co-admins, no ads for members

Plan	Price	Includes
Club Pro	₹349/month or ₹3,499/year	Unlimited clubs, paid memberships and ticketing, member export, custom branding, broadcast messages, (Phase 3) in-app video

Other revenue:

Stream	Model	Notes
Event ticketing / paid clubs	5% platform fee + payment gateway fee	Paid on Club Pro; Razorpay handles payouts
Affiliate links	~4% on Amazon India books	About ₹14 on a ₹350 book (source)
Bookstore listings	Free basic listing; ₹999/month featured	Featured: promoted in search, events, "in stock near you"
Ads	Display ads for free users	Kept light; never inside discussions
Corporate clubs (Phase 3)	₹15,000–50,000/year per company	Private workspace, SSO, engagement reports

Payments run on the web through Razorpay (UPI, cards, UPI Autopay for subscriptions). When mobile apps launch, check Google Play and App Store billing rules before selling subscriptions in-app.

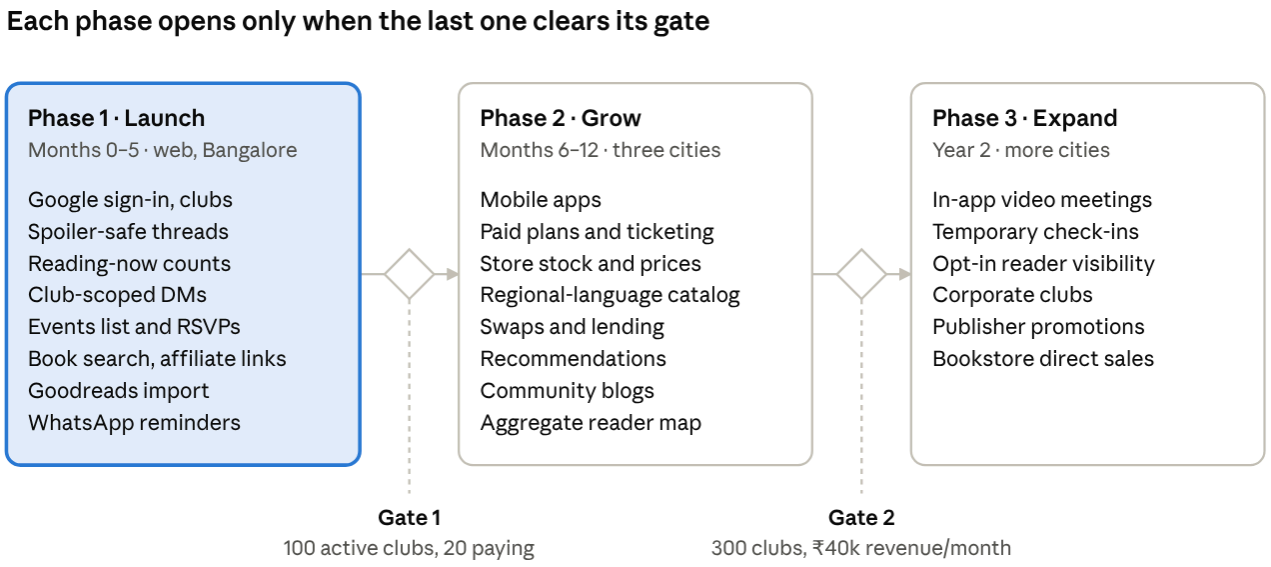
Go-to-market: Bangalore first

We launch in one city, win its organizers by hand, then copy the playbook to Mumbai, Delhi NCR, Pune, Hyderabad and Chennai.

1. **Before building (weeks 1–3):** interview 15–20 Bangalore club organizers. Confirm the pains, test the ₹149 price, and recruit 10 design partners.
2. **Private beta (month 4):** onboard the 10 design-partner clubs for free, with personal help moving members off WhatsApp.
3. **Public launch (month 5):** invite every Bangalore club we can find on Instagram and Meetup. Offer founding organizers 6 months of Club Plus free.
4. **Bookstores:** sign 10 independent and secondhand stores for free listings and co-hosted meetups. Their events fill the city calendar.
5. **Content and SEO:** "Book clubs in Bangalore" pages, city event listings, and community blogs bring organic traffic.

6. **Growth loops:** every club invite, event RSVP and shared spoiler-free thread brings new readers to sign up with Google in one tap.
7. **Next city:** once Bangalore reaches 100 active clubs, repeat steps 1–5 in the next city.

Roadmap



product roadmap · 3 phases, 2 gates

Phase 1 ships only what organizers need to move a club off WhatsApp; everything else waits until Bangalore proves clubs will stay and pay.

Financial model

In the base case, the platform covers its own running costs about 12 months after launch; paying even one full-time salary needs the optimistic case or a second city. All figures are approximate estimates for planning, in INR per month.

Running costs:

Item	Phase 1 (0–5k users)	~10k MAU	~30k MAU
Hosting, database, storage, CDN	₹5,000–8,000	₹12,000	₹30,000
Email, WhatsApp messages, SMS	₹1,000	₹5,000	₹15,000
Search, monitoring, misc. SaaS	₹1,000	₹4,000	₹8,000
Domain, legal, accounting (amortised)	₹3,000	₹4,000	₹7,000
Total	**~₹12,000**	**~₹25,000**	**~₹60,000**

Revenue scenarios, 12 months after launch:

Stream	Conservative (120 clubs, 4k MAU)	Base (300 clubs, 10k MAU)	Optimistic (800 clubs, 30k MAU)
Club Plus at ₹149	20 clubs: ₹2,980	60 clubs: ₹8,940	180 clubs: ₹26,820
Club Pro at ₹349	3 clubs: ₹1,047	10 clubs: ₹3,490	40 clubs: ₹13,960
Ticketing fees (5%)	₹3,000	₹9,000	₹30,000
Affiliate (~₹14/sale)	200 sales: ₹2,800	500 sales: ₹7,000	1,500 sales: ₹21,000
Featured bookstores at ₹999	4: ₹3,996	8: ₹7,992	25: ₹24,975
Ads	₹1,500	₹5,000	₹20,000
Total revenue	**~₹15,000**	**~₹41,000**	**~₹1.37 lakh**
Running costs	~₹15,000	~₹25,000	~₹60,000

Upfront: founder time (3–4 months to Phase 1), a ₹20,000–40,000 budget for design help and legal templates (terms, privacy policy), and company registration if not already done.

What moves the numbers most: the share of organizers who upgrade (we assume 15–25%) and how many clubs run paid events. Validate both with design partners before scaling spend.

Risks and mitigations

The biggest risk is that organizers won't leave WhatsApp; the most dangerous one is a safety incident.

Risk	Impact	Mitigation
Organizers stay on WhatsApp	No growth	Integrate with WhatsApp (reminders, share links) instead of replacing it; hand-hold the first 10 clubs
Low willingness to pay	No revenue	Charge organizers and events, not readers; test prices with design partners
Harassment or stalking via DMs or location	Users leave; reputational damage	DMs only between club members in Phase 1; no individual locations; block, report and rate limits from day one
Spam and abusive blog posts	Moderation load	Blogs in Phase 2 with new-account limits, reporting and a review queue
Weak data for Indian books	Poor search	Build our own catalog: seed from Open Library and Google Books, enrich from users and bookstores
Founder bandwidth	Slow delivery	Tight Phase 1 scope; reuse a shared community engine across projects
Goodreads or Bookclubs targets India	Competition	Local depth — stores, events, languages — is hard for a global player to copy

Compliance:

- **DPDP Act 2023:** clear consent at sign-up, a privacy notice, data deletion on request, and only the data we need (Google sign-in gives name, email and photo).
- **IT Rules 2021:** terms of use, a grievance officer, and takedown within required timelines for user content.
- **GST and payments:** register for GST once revenue crosses the threshold; Razorpay for compliant invoicing and payouts.
- **Affiliate rules:** disclose affiliate links on book pages.

Metrics and milestones

The north-star metric is **weekly active clubs**: clubs with at least one discussion post or event in the week.

Metric	3 months after launch	6 months	12 months
Active clubs	30	100	300
Monthly active readers	1,000	3,000	10,000
Paying organizers	5	20	70
Partner bookstores	5	10	25
Week-4 reader retention	30%	35%	40%
Monthly revenue	₹2,000	₹12,000	₹40,000

Next steps:

- [ ] Interview 15 Bangalore club organizers
- [ ] Pick a product name and check domain availability
- [ ] Sign up 10 design-partner clubs
- [ ] Start Phase 1 build (see the architecture document)